

The French Revolution

The French Revolution began on 14 July 1789 with the storming of the Bastille in Paris. It ended the Bourbon monarchy and ultimately led to the rise of Napoleon Bonaparte.

Causes included financial crisis from France's support of the American Revolution, the burden of taxation on the Third Estate, and the spread of Enlightenment ideas by Jean-Jacques Rousseau, Voltaire, and Montesquieu.

The Estates-General convened on 5 May 1789 at Versailles. The Third Estate declared itself the National Assembly on 17 June. The Declaration of the Rights of Man and of the Citizen was adopted on 26 August 1789.

King Louis XVI was executed by guillotine on 21 January 1793, followed by Marie Antoinette on 16 October 1793. Maximilien Robespierre led the Committee of Public Safety during the Reign of Terror (September 1793 - July 1794) and was himself guillotined on 28 July 1794.

Napoleon Bonaparte seized power in the coup of 18 Brumaire (9 November 1799), ending the revolutionary period and beginning the Napoleonic era.